

Von der Leyen sets her course

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Presented by Altana By GERARDO FORTUNA with ZOYA SHEFTALOVICH CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you from Strasbourg, where I've already witnessed

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you from Strasbourg, where I've already witnessed a minor miracle this week: Manfred Weber, Iratxe García and Valérie Hayer laughing together by the lifts after meeting Ursula von der Leyen. Does it mean a calmer State of the Union ahead? We'll see.

In today's Playbook:

- How do you make the case for AI when everyone's freaking out?
- The EPP and S&D are squabbling again.
- Faces in the crowd: Virginijus Sinkevičius, Mark Carney, Sam Altman, Jensen Huang, Roberta Metsola, Brando Benifei, Robert Schuman, Pedro Sánchez, Andrea Maceiras, Assita Kanko and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya captures the mood in Strasbourg as von der Leyen prepares to deliver her legacy-defining address, while Ian hosts from Brussels. Plus we'll have a special episode of the podcast after von der Leyen speaks, analyzing what she said, what she meant and what she left out.

****A message from Altana: Altana is the AI network where businesses, logistics providers, and governments are rearchitecting global trade. With Altana, businesses can prove compliance before goods ship and build more efficient, resilient, and secure supply chains. Logistics providers can automate the full brokerage workflow, and governments can promote economic security, manage borders, and enable the flow of trusted trade.****

DRIVING THE DAY

SOTEU IS FINALLY HERE ... BUT THEN WHAT? We pretty much know what Ursula von der Leyen is going to say in her biggest address of the year . The harder question is what comes next.

Von der Leyen's sixth State of the Union will be critical to defining the remainder of her Commission presidency. If she has something big left to do, she'd better get on and do it.

Or, as Parliament President Roberta Metsola put it here in Strasbourg yesterday: "The legislative files that will be proposed or that will come this year will realistically be the ones that will be closed by the end of the mandate."

With a difficult electoral year ahead, today will tell us a lot about what von der Leyen wants to do with the rest of her time in the EU executive's top job. Watch particularly for where she gets personal: Social media restrictions for children, wearing her hat as a former family minister; big security plans, drawing on her time as a defense minister. But the broader ambition she signals will be just as revealing as any individual policy.

Can von der Leyen get Europe behind her? She's got several factors in her favor. Nearly two years into her second five-year term, the Commission president has more control than in the past, with officials describing a firmer grip on her team.

And the Parliament is different, too. Playbook has been doing some highly scientific research around Strasbourg — hanging around the notorious Swan bar, the corridors and outside the hemicycle. The verdict: It's noticeably calmer than during the run of confidence votes against her.

Virginijus Sinkevičius, a commissioner from von der Leyen's first term, now a Green MEP, thinks the president is in a strong position. "She's more powerful than [in] my time," he told Playbook. "You also improve and learn how to do your job by doing it."

An official from the center-right European People's Party (von der Leyen's camp) agreed with that when Playbook bumped into them while queuing at the Parliament bar. They pointed to the way von der Leyen has structured her second Commission — and the concentration of power around her own cabinet.

That doesn't mean she's getting everything right. Arrangements for Canadian PM Mark Carney's appearance in Parliament on Thursday were something of a mess, with von der Leyen apparently not planning to attend — until she was. Canada's ambassador had made Ottawa's expectations clear: Carney would attend her speech, so "it would be great if she could be there," as Sebastian Starcevic and Max Grier report .

Adding to the awkwardness: The EU is set to rebuff Carney's push for a "unique alliance" with the bloc, the FT is reporting this morning .

Another thought: There could be more at stake for von der Leyen today than charting a course for the remainder of her presidency. "I think they'll be listening in Berlin," said one right-wing Parliament official. Speculation that she wants to become German president has faded — but never quite disappeared.

FOLLOW THE SPEECH: Von der Leyen is due to speak at 9 a.m. Watch it live here . Our reporters in Strasbourg, Brussels and beyond will be tracking the address — and the reaction — in our live blog , so stay tuned.

BIG AND BREAKING

DIRTY WORK: The EU will carry on sending hundreds of thousands of tons of plastic waste to Turkey every year, despite growing evidence of environmental damage and mismanagement, Fiona McNally reports.

ACTIONS, NOT WORDS: Firefighters are battling away flattery from government leaders, responding that they need resources — not applause — to put out fires in a Europe looking increasingly like a tinder box, Zia Weise reports.

CARBON CRUNCH: While capitals are fighting over whether von der Leyen should roll back her Green Deal to boost industry, a Coreper I meeting of deputy ambassadors this morning looks set to end in deadlock — after Germany joined a bid to block efforts by Czechia, Poland and others to relax carbon rules, according to a document seen by POLITICO.

AI APOCALYPSE

TECH TIGHTROPE: The U.S. and China are turning artificial intelligence into a geopolitical contest. Leading industry figures are issuing grave warnings about the dangers of advanced systems. Von der Leyen's task: Reassure Europeans who are spooked by the tech while emphasizing the opportunities it could bring.

Her message: Europe must avoid becoming so risk-averse that it misses AI's potential to transform its economy and industry, particularly as the U.S. and China move ahead.

Apocalypse soon? The backdrop is troubling. Over the weekend, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei called for a slowdown in the development of frontier AI, warning that safety measures may not be keeping pace with the technology. That was backed by OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, xAI founder Elon Musk and Google DeepMind's Demis Hassabis. (Though Nvidia boss Jensen Huang reckons the industry doesn't need new laws, my stateside colleagues report .)

Europe's dilemma: The EU's seminal AI Act is operational, and it's meant to protect safety and fundamental rights. But tough enforcement could deepen concerns that the bloc is falling behind. Meanwhile, leaving AI unchecked, or relying entirely on systems developed elsewhere, could create serious security vulnerabilities.

"We already open the newspapers and see news about tens of thousands of jobs lost every day," said one national official, granted anonymity to speak freely. "We can't be left behind on this too."

The other big risk to Europe: If it tries to regulate American AI companies, U.S. President Donald Trump will hit back. Trump has dismissed Amodei's call for an AI slowdown as a "hoax," arguing that regulation would undermine the U.S. in the race with China. He signaled that Washington is unlikely to adopt broad AI regulation.

"Von der Leyen is too scared of Trump," Brando Benifei, the European Parliament's lead lawmaker on AI, said, accusing the EU of hesitating to enforce its rules. Instead of listening to Trump, she should "listen to Carney, who will be with us ... We should not chicken out because Trump has demonstrated that when it goes wrong, you need to be tough."

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The State of the Union speech is delivered in Strasbourg, but how long has the European Parliament been meeting in the French city? Well, since before there was a Parliament as we know it. The Common Assembly of the European Coal and Steel Community (the precursor to the Parliament) held its first meeting in Strasbourg in 1952. The European Parliamentary Assembly (the Parliament's original name) picked its first president, Robert Schuman, in Strasbourg in 1958, and EU member states formally designated Strasbourg as the official seat of the Parliament in 1992.

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STATE OF DISUNION

THE COALITION BREAKS DOWN (AGAIN): The EPP and the Socialists and Democrats have flunked the first major post-summer test of whether they can repair their relationship, failing to agree on a text setting out the Parliament's position on the Ceuta migrant crisis, Max Grier writes.

Yesterday's negotiations ended without a deal despite a flurry of proposals going back and forth before the 7 p.m. deadline. That's a blow to those pushing to revive the alliance after months of quarreling over the EPP voting with the far right and the S&D's increasingly confrontational stance. And it casts a shadow over von der Leyen's State of the Union, with her key parliamentary supporters clashing once again.

The main disagreement was over the EPP wanting to blame Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's government and its migration policies for the problems in Ceuta, which was a red line for the S&D, according to officials familiar with the talks.

Next step: Despite the lack of a deal, the S&D expects the EPP "not to side with the extreme right when it comes to amendments and to uphold the responsibility that comes with being a pro-European political group," said Andrea Maceiras, a spokesperson for President Iratxe García. Right-wing and far-right groups could support the EPP's version of the text with some amendments.

A choice to make: Assita Kanko, the lead lawmaker on the file for the right-wing European Conservatives and Reformists, called on the EPP to have "courage" and embrace the right-wing alliance. The "EPP is trying to sleep in several beds, but you cannot be with S&D and also be with us at the same time," she said.

****Next Tuesday, Sept. 22, watch online your favorite Playbook authors and podcast hosts live as they unpack the power plays and policy fights you've been reading about - with the same policymakers, diplomats and insiders who usually just get quoted. Register here to watch online .****

DASHBOARD

How will von der Leyen's State of the Union land beyond the Brussels bubble? POLITICO polling in three of the EU's largest countries, Germany, France and Spain, shows EU citizens view her performance with a critical eye — if they know her at all .

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

STAYING HOME: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz has canceled a trip to New York for the United Nations General Assembly next week, as his party braces for another tough election in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania on Sunday.

WAKE-UP CALL: The summer's extreme weather sparked a "realization" in Brussels that the EU needs to step up its climate-proofing efforts, Parliament President Roberta Metsola said.

SUMMIT SCOOP: Migration, trade and enlargement will dominate October's European Council, according to a draft document seen by Playbook's Gabriel Gavin.

GENOCIDE DENIAL: MEPs voted to waive the parliamentary immunity of far-right lawmaker Grzegorz Braun, who is facing Holocaust denial charges in Poland, Daria Zakharova writes.

RAGE AGAINST THE MACHINE: Nigel Farage is preparing for a legal battle to hold onto £72 million in donations from crypto billionaires, my colleagues in London write.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny in patches. High 19C.

THANKS FROM EUROPE: In their bilateral later today, Roberta Metsola will give Mark Carney a 1940 Canadian MK II steel combat helmet, Playbook has learned — a symbol of Europe's gratitude to the Canadians who fought and died here during World War II. The helmet was found near Saint-Sylvain, outside Caen, in May 2025.

SPOTTED ... at the rentrée reception hosted by the U.S. Mission to the EU's public diplomacy section: The U.S. Mission's Norman Thatcher Scharpf and Donna LaPorte Scharpf, John Simmons, Adrienne Bory, Sara Mathews, Meg Riggs, Teresa Dominguez-Piedade and Kamy Le Tran; AmCham EU's Thibaut L'Ortye; the U.K. Mission's Caitlin Griffith; the Irish perm rep's Eoin Flavin; Spanish perm rep's Javier Molina; Slovak perm rep's Pavol Kucharovic; Fulbright Director Erica Lutes; Bruegel Director Jeromin Zettelmeyer; Bloomberg's Suzanne Lynch; the FT's Barbara Moens and Henry Foy; El Pais' Silvia Ayuso; journalist Matthew Karnitschnig; The Economist's Stanley Pignal; The New York Times' Emily Rauhala; and POLITICO's Mathieu Pollet, Jordyn Dahl, Gavin Sundwall, Kathryn Carlson and Camille Gijs.

SRB BLAST TRAGEDY: The EU's staff union has written to its office management arm demanding answers after a gas explosion at the Single Resolution Board's offices on Treurenberg in central Brussels killed a firefighter and injured two Sibelga employees and another emergency worker, according to a letter seen by Playbook's Gabriel Gavin.

"This serious accident, which resulted in the death of a rescue worker, took place in a European Union building," the request reads. The SRB is the EU agency responsible for managing failing banks in the eurozone's banking union. "Who commissioned the works? Was a risk assessment carried out before work began, including, in particular, plans of the gas pipework?" Union representatives are now demanding a report along with "measures to prevent a recurrence of the accident."

The Commission said it stands ready to provide further assistance if needed, and expressed condolences and sympathies.

DON'T GO ALONE: It's debate night tonight at The Sister Brussels Café at Rue Chair et Pain in the center, with four teams of two tasked with advocating and opposing the idea "that a shift to collectivist thinking will help alleviate Europe's problems." It's free to attend, and even those with no prior experience are invited to take part .

FULL MARX FOR TRYING: The nomadic Museum of Capitalism, which describes itself as a traveling show dedicated to the "origins, hopes, limits and alternatives" of the system that governs our lives, is open in Forest from 2 p.m. as part of a limited run . No reservation is required but it requests a donation of €2.

****Don't miss out on exclusive insights from the much-anticipated State of the Union speech. In our virtual briefing on Thursday, Sept. 17 at 4 p.m. CEST our policy reporters break down the key issues on von der Leyen's radar, what matters most, and what it means for the coming months. Sign up now .****

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is gearing up for a fight to keep his chancellorship.

Paris: France's budget fight is getting messier , with Sébastien Lecornu ordering ministers to put a lid on spending.

London: Andy Burnham will meet Mark Carney in Liverpool — then the prime ministers will go to an Everton football match together.

Washington: The Supreme Court's rejection of Donald Trump's efforts to restrict mail-in voting was a blow to the Republicans' midterm hopes — but Democrats aren't taking it for granted .

Ottawa: At Mark Carney's swishy investment summit , some of the world's biggest investors see an upside in the country's trade war with the U.S.

Canberra: One Nation was quick to unveil its migration policy — but Labor has yet to show its hand .

AGENDA

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen delivers her State of the Union address to the European Parliament in Strasbourg at 9 a.m., followed by a debate. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney will attend, along with commissioners and MEPs.

— Carney will meet bilaterally with von der Leyen, and with European Parliament President Roberta Metsola at 2 p.m.

— European Council President António Costa continues his "Tour des Capitales" with meetings in Brussels with Belgian Prime Minister Bart de Wever, EIB President Nadia Calviño and EBRD President Odile Renaud-Basso.

— Coreper I and Coreper II meetings in Brussels at 10 a.m.

— Metsola signs legislative acts at 4 p.m. and receives Bulgarian President Iliana Iotova at 4:15 p.m.

— UNESCO Assistant Director-General Mariya Gabriel meets Health Commissioner Olivér Várhelyi, Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica and Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra.

— Agriculture and Food Commissioner Christophe Hansen delivers a keynote speech, “Réformer l’Europe,” at a Chamber of Commerce event in Luxembourg.

BIRTHDAYS

Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque; MEP Ilhan Kyuchyuk; former European Commissioner Pierre Moscovici; Swedish politician and former MEP Jytte Guteland; European Commission’s Diego Torres and Benjamin van Zeveren; NBC’s Richard Engel; economist Johannes Boehm; Luxembourg’s PM Luc Frieden.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Altana:** The rules of global trade have changed. Tariffs are tools of statecraft. Supply chains are leverage. And the old frameworks — built for a world of open markets and stable alliances — no longer hold. Policymakers need a new architecture. One that enables enforcement and trade simultaneously. One that lets governments collaborate across borders without compromising what's sovereign. Altana is that architecture. Our AI-powered network maps supply chains to the product level, verifying origin, process, and compliance before goods ever ship. Government agencies across the UK, US, Australia, and Singapore already connect through Altana to design and enforce trade and economic security policy — while businesses manage trusted trade on the same shared platform. The next era of trade won't be won by those who build the highest walls. It will be won by those who build the deepest trust. Visit altana.ai to learn how Altana can support your trade and economic security objectives .**

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